

Subject Code	ENGL5039
Subject Title	Professional communication and AI: Theory and practice
Credit Value	3
Level	5
Pre-requisite/Co-requisite/Exclusion	N/A
Objectives	This course will develop students' understanding of how and why humans communicate in particular ways with specific reference to professional and workplace contexts. The course will draw on general theories of communication (e.g., Process model of communication, Communication accommodation theory) as well as recent work on interpersonal and organisational communication. This content will be supplemented by interdisciplinary approaches to topics from the fields of pragmatics, rhetoric, social psychology and semiotics. This knowledge will be used to explore the continued evolution of human communication and recent extensions into computer mediated communication, human-machine communication and Artificial Intelligence in professional contexts. Practical activities will focus specifically on the use of visual and written forms of communication in contemporary workplaces including in virtual and online spaces. These activities will support students in learning how to use relevant theories and practical strategies to optimise communication in diverse professional contexts. Activities will include analysing a range of everyday communication tasks such as giving good and bad news, and making requests and complaints.
Intended Learning Outcomes	Upon completion of the subject, students will be able to: Category A: Professional/academic knowledge and skills - Understand the need for effective communication skills in relation to career development; - Demonstrate skills needed to analyse communication in a variety of professional contexts; - Demonstrate communicative competence and confidence in written forms of communication with awareness of dimensions of readability, conciseness, persuasion, and reader-centred writing. Category B: Attributes for all-roundedness - Display analytical reasoning, critical thinking, and problem-solving skills by: - thinking in a logical manner, supporting ideas with well-reasoned arguments and evidence - evaluating information and evidence critically, recognising flaws or inconsistencies in arguments. - Demonstrate skills and creativity in problem-solving.
Subject Synopsis/ Indicative Syllabus	The subject provides a comprehensive overview of key theories and practices related to professional communication. The syllabus is arranged around the following key topics which will be covered iteratively in lectures and seminars: - Interdisciplinary approaches to professional communication: • Interpersonal and organisational communication • Pragmatics

	• Rhetoric • Semiotics • Social psychology 2. Communication modalities in the modern workplace - developments in visual and mediated communication, human-machine communication and Artificial Intelligence. 3. Creative thinking and problem-solving in professional workplaces in relation to: • Persuasive communication • Conflict and miscommunication • Giving good and bad news • Handling complaints, requests and rejections • Ethics and professional communication																																								
Teaching/Learning Methodology	The teaching and learning approach will be task-based, student-centred, interactive, and reflective. Students will learn how to identify, evaluate and improve aspects of professional communication through small group discussions, role-plays, classroom presentations, seminars and simulated communication activities. This subject requires critical and creative thinking, problem-solving and attention to detail.																																								
Assessment Methods in Alignment with Intended Learning Outcomes	<table><tr><th rowspan="2">Specific assessment methods/tasks</th><th rowspan="2">% weighting</th><th colspan="5">Intended subject learning outcomes to be assessed (Please tick as appropriate)</th></tr><tr><th>a</th><th>b</th><th>c</th><th>d</th><th>e</th></tr><tr><td>1. Reflective essay(s)</td><td>25%</td><td>✓</td><td></td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td></tr><tr><td>2. Group presentation(s)</td><td>35%</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td></td><td>✓</td><td></td></tr><tr><td>3. In-class test</td><td>40%</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td></td></tr><tr><td>Total</td><td>100%</td><td colspan="5"></td></tr></table> Explanation of the appropriateness of the assessment methods in assessing the intended learning outcomes: The reflective essay requires students to analyse communication based on their own professional or workplace experiences. The analytical skills students develop through this initial task are then extended and applied to the analysis and presentation of different types of communication texts. The in-class test assesses students’ skills in understanding and applying their theoretical and practical knowledge through a series of multiple-choice, short answer and task-based activities related to professional communication.	Specific assessment methods/tasks	% weighting	Intended subject learning outcomes to be assessed (Please tick as appropriate)					a	b	c	d	e	1. Reflective essay(s)	25%	✓		✓	✓	✓	2. Group presentation(s)	35%	✓	✓		✓		3. In-class test	40%	✓	✓	✓	✓		Total	100%					
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Student Study Effort Expected	<table><tr><td>Class contact:</td><td></td></tr><tr><td>• Seminars</td><td>39 hrs</td></tr><tr><td>Other student study effort:</td><td></td></tr><tr><td>• Private study</td><td>81 hrs</td></tr><tr><td>Total student study effort</td><td>120 hrs</td></tr></table>	Class contact:		• Seminars	39 hrs	Other student study effort:		• Private study	81 hrs	Total student study effort	120 hrs																														
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Reading List and References	Adler, R. B., & Elmhorst, J. M. (2010). <i>Communicating at work: Principles and practices for business and the professions</i> (10th ed.). McGrawHill Higher Education. Bhatia, V. J. (1993). <i>Analysing genre: Language use in professional settings</i>. Longman. Bovee, C. L., & Thill, J. V. (2021). <i>Excellence in business communication</i>. Prentice Hall. Gunkel, D. J. (2020). <i>An introduction to communication and artificial intelligence</i>. Polity Press. Levinson, S. C. (1983). <i>Pragmatics</i>. Cambridge University Press. Miller, K. (2005). <i>Communication theories: Perspectives, processes, and contexts</i> (2nd ed.). McGraw Hill. Communication Accommodation Theory: Giles, H. (Ed.) (2016). <i>Communication accommodation theory: Negotiating personal relationships and social identities across contexts</i>. Cambridge University Press. – 10 chapters on various aspects of communication accommodation theory Business settings: Ehrenreich, S. (2009). English as a lingua franca in multinational corporations: Exploring business communities of practice. In A. Mauranen & E. Ranta (Eds.), <i>English as a lingua franca: Studies and findings</i> (pp. 126–151). Cambridge Scholars Publishing. Pitzl, M.-L. (2009). “We should not wake up any dogs”: Idiom and metaphor in ELF. In A. Mauranen & E. Ranta (Eds.), <i>English as a lingua franca: Studies and findings</i> (pp. 298–322). Cambridge Scholars Publishing. Pullin Stark, P. (2009). No joke- this is serious!: Power, solidarity and humour in business English as a lingua franca (BELF). In A. Mauranen & E. Ranta (Eds.), <i>English as a lingua franca: Studies and findings</i> (pp. 152–177). Cambridge Scholars Publishing. Healthcare settings: Cass, A., Lowell, A., Christie, M., Snelling, P. L., Flack, M., Marrnganyin, B., & Brown, I. (2002). Sharing the true stories: Improving communication between Aboriginal patients and healthcare workers. <i>The Medical Journal of Australia</i>, 176, 466–470. Lin, I., Green, C., & Bessarab, D. (2016). ‘Yarn with me’: Applying clinical yarning to improve clinician-patient communication in Aboriginal health care. <i>Australian Journal of Primary Health</i>, 22, 377–382. van Wieringen, J. C. M., Harmsen, J. A. M., & Bruijnzeels, M. A. (2002). Intercultural communication in general practice. <i>European Journal of Public Health</i>, 12, 63–68. Law settings: Eades, D. (2000). I don't think it's an answer to the question: Silencing Aboriginal witnesses in court. <i>Language in Society</i>, 29(2), 161–195.
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	Rickford, J. R., & King, S. (2016). Language and linguistics on trial: Hearing Rachel Jeantel (and other vernacular speakers) in the courtroom and beyond. <i>Language</i>, 92(4), 948–988. Aviation settings: Kim, H. (2018). What constitutes professional communication in aviation: Is language proficiency enough for testing purposes? <i>Language Testing</i>, 35(3), 403–426. Kim, H., & Friginal, E. (2026). Revisiting aviation English as a lingua franca: Insights from domain specialists. <i>Applied Linguistics Review</i>, 1–25. Advanced online publication.
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Revised by Dr Hyejeong Kim in April 2026